BUDGET MEAL PREP GUIDE

30 Days of Meals Under $5 Each

Empire Rewards — Free Edition

INTRODUCTION

The USDA reports the average American household wastes $1,500 of food per year — roughly 30–40% of everything purchased. Combined with impulse purchases, last-minute takeout, and delivery apps, grocery spending spirals far beyond what's necessary.

This guide gives you a complete 30-day system. The meal calendar tells you what to cook each day. The shopping lists are pre-organized by store aisle. Every recipe costs under $5 per serving.

PART 1: THE THREE PILLARS OF BUDGET MEAL PREP

Pillar 1: Plan Around Overlapping Ingredients

The most expensive mistake is buying unique ingredients for each recipe. Plan a week where meals share a base — shredded chicken becomes tacos Monday, a rice bowl Tuesday, and a salad Wednesday. This single technique cuts grocery bills by 20%.

Pillar 2: Cook Once, Eat Twice (or Thrice)

Every recipe here doubles or triples cleanly. Cook two pounds of ground beef on Sunday and split it three ways: pasta sauce, taco filling, soup base. Three dinners in one session.

Pillar 3: Store It Right

Clear, stackable containers make your fridge organized and your meals visible. If you can see it, you'll eat it. If it's buried, it becomes waste.

PART 2: THE 30-DAY MEAL CALENDAR

WEEK 1 — Chicken Base

Monday: Chicken tacos

Tuesday: Chicken rice bowl

Wednesday: Chicken salad

Thursday: Chicken pasta

Friday: Chicken soup

Saturday: Leftover remix

Sunday: Prep day

WEEK 2 — Ground Beef Base

Monday: Beef tacos

Tuesday: Spaghetti bolognese

Wednesday: Shepherd's pie

Thursday: Beef chili

Friday: Stuffed peppers

Saturday: Leftover remix

Sunday: Prep day

WEEK 3 — Bean & Veg Base

Monday: Black bean burritos

Tuesday: Veggie stir-fry

Wednesday: Lentil soup

Thursday: Chickpea curry

Friday: Bean quesadillas

Saturday: Leftover remix

Sunday: Prep day

WEEK 4 — Mix & Match

Monday: Egg fried rice

Tuesday: Tuna pasta bake

Wednesday: Breakfast-for-dinner

Thursday: Quesadilla night

Friday: Pizza from scratch

Saturday: Leftover remix

Sunday: Celebrate

PART 3: THE SUNDAY BATCH COOKING SCHEDULE

Three hours on Sunday gives you five days of meals. The exact timeline:

0:00–0:15 — Preheat oven, start rice cooker, boil water for pasta

0:15–0:45 — Brown ground beef and shred chicken; season both

0:45–1:15 — Chop vegetables; roast root vegetables in oven

1:15–1:45 — Cook pasta and sauces; portion into containers

1:45–2:15 — Assemble rice bowls and salads; prep snacks

2:15–2:45 — Label all containers with dates and contents

2:45–3:00 — Clean up, store meals, plan next week's shop

PART 4: WEEKLY SHOPPING LISTS BY STORE AISLE

PRODUCE

- Seasonal fruits (see seasonal calendar)
- Seasonal vegetables
- Salad greens
- Onions, garlic, potatoes
- Bananas, apples, oranges

DAIRY & EGGS

- Milk
- Eggs (dozen)
- Butter
- Cheese (block, not shredded)
- Yogurt (large container)

MEAT & PROTEIN

- Chicken thighs (cheaper than breast)
- Ground beef or turkey
- Canned tuna

- Dried or canned beans
- Peanut butter

PANTRY

- Rice (5 lb bag)
- Pasta (3 lb)
- Oats
- Canned diced tomatoes (4 cans)
- Tomato paste
- Coconut milk
- Cooking oil

FROZEN

- Frozen mixed vegetables
- Frozen fruit
- Frozen fish fillets

BAKERY

- Store-brand bread
- Tortillas

HOUSEHOLD

- Paper towels
- Toilet paper
- Dish soap
- Laundry detergent

PART 5: 30 RECIPES UNDER $5 PER SERVING

BREAKFAST (5 recipes)

1. Overnight oats with peanut butter and banana
2. Egg and cheese breakfast burritos (batch of 12)

3. Oatmeal with brown sugar and frozen berries

4. Greek yogurt parfait with granola

5. Scrambled egg and spinach wraps

LUNCH (10 recipes)

6. Chicken and rice bowl

7. Black bean and corn salad

8. Tuna pasta salad

9. Bean and cheese quesadillas

10. Leftover chili over rice

11. Egg salad sandwiches

12. Lentil soup with bread

13. Chickpea and cucumber salad

14. Turkey and cheese wraps

15. Veggie stir-fry over rice

DINNER (15 recipes)

16. Chicken tacos with cabbage slaw

17. Spaghetti bolognese

18. Beef chili

19. Shepherd's pie

20. Stuffed bell peppers

21. Chicken and vegetable soup

22. Chicken pasta with tomato sauce

23. Black bean burritos

24. Lentil curry over rice

25. Chickpea coconut curry

26. Egg fried rice

27. Tuna pasta bake

28. Bean quesadillas

29. Homemade pizza (dough from scratch)

30. Roasted chicken thighs with root vegetables

PART 6: THE 25 PANTRY STAPLES

Keep these stocked and you're always 2–3 ingredients from a meal:

Grains: white rice, brown rice, pasta, oats, tortillas

Proteins: dried beans, canned beans, eggs, canned tuna, peanut butter

Canned goods: diced tomatoes, tomato paste, coconut milk, corn

Oils & fats: olive oil, vegetable oil, butter

Seasonings: salt, pepper, garlic powder, onion powder, cumin, chili powder, paprika

Condiments: soy sauce, hot sauce, mayonnaise, mustard

PART 7: THE 15 LEFTOVER MAKEOVER IDEAS

1. Last night's chicken → chicken salad sandwich
2. Last night's rice → fried rice
3. Last night's roasted vegetables → frittata
4. Last night's pasta → pasta frittata
5. Last night's chili → chili cheese baked potatoes
6. Last night's tacos → taco salad
7. Last night's soup → soup over rice
8. Last night's chicken → quesadillas
9. Last night's beef → shepherd's pie
10. Last night's beans → bean dip
11. Last night's vegetables → vegetable soup
12. Last night's eggs → breakfast burrito
13. Last night's rice → rice pudding
14. Last night's bread → croutons
15. Last night's fruit → smoothie

PART 8: BUDGET BREAKDOWN

Average cost per serving: $2.50–$4.00

Average weekly grocery spend (family of 4): $120–$150

Average monthly grocery spend (family of 4): $480–$600

Savings versus unplanned shopping: $200–$400/month

PART 9: WHY MEAL PREP WORKS

- Reduces food waste by 40–60%
- Eliminates last-minute takeout ($15–$30 per meal)
- Reduces impulse purchases at the store by 30–50%
- Saves 5–8 hours per week on cooking and cleanup
- Makes nutrition tracking automatic — you know exactly what you're eating

FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS

How much can meal prep save?

$200–$400/month for the average household.

How long does weekly prep take?

2–3 hours on a single day.

What's included in the download?

30-day meal calendar, weekly shopping lists, 30 recipes, batch cooking schedules, pantry checklist, leftover makeover ideas.

Is this good for beginners?

Yes. Every recipe uses simple ingredients and basic cooking methods.

CONCLUSION

You now have:

- A complete 30-day meal calendar

- Categorized shopping lists
- 30 recipes under $5 per serving
- A Sunday batch cooking schedule
- A pantry essentials checklist
- 15 leftover makeover ideas

Follow the calendar. Shop the lists. Cook on Sunday. Eat well all week for under $5 per meal.

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